

The capitalist system lives because of our continued participation in it. And it thrives on mocking socialists and activists as “burnouts” or unrealistic, naive dreamers. It feeds on every Facebook post by a rich baby boomer about entitled millennials asking for more from their employer. Peyton-Carrillo knows people romanticize competition instead of working together. They think, “How could I beat that other motherfucker across the table from me??” not, “How can I work with this person?”

There was a tweet that went viral in 2017 about a woman who was interviewing for a job with a tech company called Skip The Dishes. Before the interview, she emailed the company and asked what the wages and benefits would look like for her position. The company, citing her interest in money over the company, rescinded their offer of an interview. The comments about this were split between people arguing that her question was inappropriate and people saying she was completely within her rights to ask. Some said employees have a right to know how much they’re going to be paid for labor so they can decide if it’s worth it to spend the money (on clothes, taking time off existing work, getting a babysitter, transit, and lots more) to come interview.

Other people argued it was impolite or “not proper etiquette” to ask about compensation before a job interview. Instead, you have to go in and make it seem like you’re obsessed with the company and would work there for free, creating an illusion that people don’t work for money. Fuck. That. Are we such kowtowing sniveling cowards that we have to let companies treat us like shit and pay us shit just to get a job—any job?

We reach dangerous territory when we deny ourselves humanity just so we can land a job at a place that clearly expects us not to value pay, meaning they’re going to pay next to nothing for long hours and hard work.

You love people. You don’t love companies (as the writer Ashley C. Ford would say). Too many employers preach a “family” atmosphere, but this is a manipulation tactic to stop you from, out of guilt, asking for a promotion or higher salary or better conditions. Maybe they don’t provide basic health benefits; maybe they keep you overtime without compensation.

Not wanting to participate is not entitlement. When you start willy-nilly labeling things “entitlement,” you’re on a slippery slope to abetting the system